

Ten Must-Have Open Source Tools for Systems Administrators



This article intends to make the job of systems administrators vastly easier by introducing them to 10 open source tools they cannot live without.

In my experience, I have used a bunch of tools for everyday systems admin tasks. But selecting the top 10 tools was not an easy task. However, I have considered user reviews, functionality, ease of use and community support for further development to select the best tools. Before discussing the tools, I must mention the important roles of a systems administrator. Though there are primary tasks like system preparations, OS installation and configuration, user administration, etc, involved in systems admin roles, system performance, log analysis and system/data recovery tasks are very important when there is an issue reported by a customer or by internal teams. So I have given more importance to the tools used in that space.

Nmon

In general, systems administrators use *top*, *sar* (system activity reports) and other such commands to monitor the performance of various Linux sub-systems (CPU, memory, I/O, etc), and these commands are available in most Linux distributions. Why

do we need to use so many commands, when one command can give a huge amount of information about a system's performance? Yes, Nmon is an open source utility that provides system performance data on a single screen. Nmon stands for Nigel's performance monitor. It provides the data in two ways: 1) on-screen data that gets updated once every two seconds, and 2) exports the data to a CSV (Comma Separated Values) file for later analysis and plotting of graphs.

Rsyslog

Rsyslog is a replacement for Syslog, and it offers many benefits over the other log servers (Syslog and Syslog-ng). Rsyslog collects and forwards the logs to a centralised server. It is the default log server for the latest versions of Red Hat Enterprise Linux, as well as many other Linux distributions. Maintaining a centralised log server is one of the primary requirements for most IT organisations and systems administrators. Log management helps to meet IT security audit and compliance requirements. Inadequate